After Deka's arrest, Dr Brojen Gogoi, who had handled the negotiations for the kidnapped employee and been the person of contact from the Tatas with ULFA, also found himself in the eye of a storm. There was evidence that he had accompanied Deka to Mumbai for her treatment. The state government's intelligence wing had also concluded that Gogoi was seen with ULFA leaders in Switzerland for a meeting of the Unrepresented Nations and Peoples Organization (UNPO). It led the Assam police to launch a massive hunt for him. He was in the US at the time on a study trip. On 13 September, Interpol issued an international alert for him. The news that the police was hunting for him led to adverse publicity for the Tata Group as well.

Caught in the Crosshairs

After the DGP's press conference, Ratan, who set much store by the reputation of the group, went into damage control mode. He reached out directly to the masses to counter the DGP's assertions, as was his wont. Before the end of the day of the press conference, Tata Tea issued a press release which countered the DGP's version. It said, 'The company pays money directly to the hospitals for actual treatment of the patients under the scheme and it does not pay any amount directly to beneficiaries.' It went on to say: 'Some persons, reportedly belonging to the ULFA organization, have apparently availed of this (medical assistance scheme) and benefited by way of medical treatment in Mumbai. Other than this the company has no involvement. The company is proud of its medical assistance schemes and will continue to run them.'

'We were told that a certain Ms Barua was suffering from chronic blood disorder along with pregnancy and required special attention from a Bombay hospital where such treatment was available. We have never paid any extortion money, not even in the case of Bolin Bordoloi,' Kidwai emphasized later.

A press release titled 'Tata Tea's Efforts to Bring Healing Touch to Assam Through Medical Aid Scheme' was sent out on 12 September. In it, the company went on to add that this one-off instance occurred because it was impractical to verify the antecedents of every patient who approached the company for medical treatment. The communique said, 'An aberration in the implementation of the scheme at the local level cannot be treated as a